

FLINTLOCK PISTOLS (1801–30)

By the beginning of the 19th century, the flintlock mechanism had been in use for more than two hundred years but was still the principal ignition system for firearms. Flintlocks fitted to privately purchased weapons, such as the dueling pistol on this page, had some refinements, including the addition of prawls and steadying spurs on the trigger guard, to make the gun easier to aim, but the basic principle of flint on steel remained unchanged. Armies and navies in Europe and North America continued to use flintlock pistols well into the 1830s.



▲ FLEMISH POCKET PISTOL

Date 1805

Origin Netherlands

Barrel 4¼in (10.9cm)

Caliber .52in (13.2mm)

This box-lock pocket pistol has an integral spring-loaded bayonet, operated by pulling back on the trigger guard. The catch on its lock prevented the cock from falling accidentally. This kind of safety catch had been present in some pistols since the mid-16th century. This gun's lock plate is engraved and the butt is finely carved—the work of A. Juliard, a Flemish gunmaker of repute.



▲ HARPERS FERRY MODEL 1805 PISTOL

Date 1805

Origin US

Barrel 10in (25.4cm)

Caliber .54in (13.7mm)

The Model 1805 was the first pistol manufactured at the newly established Federal Armory and Arsenal at Harpers Ferry (in modern-day West Virginia). It was robust enough to be reversed and wielded as a club if required.



▲ FLINTLOCK DUELING PISTOL

Date 1815

Origin UK

Barrel 9in (23cm)

Caliber .51in (13.1mm)

Pistols specifically designed for dueling made their first appearance in Britain after 1780. They were invariably sold as a matched pair, cased, with all the accessories necessary for their use (see pp.106–07). “Saw handle” butts with pronounced prawls and steadying spurs on the trigger guard were later additions.